User Test Plan: Evaluating a New Public Library Catalog

Situating Context

A public library is planning to replace its old web-based catalog with a new one. The design team wants to make the new catalog easier to use and improve the overall experience for readers.

They also want to understand whether users can discover new books when they are just browsing and whether they can find a specific book faster when they already know what they are looking for.

The purpose of this study is to test the new catalog with real users. I will observe how they use it and compare it with the old catalog. I also want to understand what works well and what needs to be improved.

Objectives

1. Formative**:** Find common usability problems in the new catalog. This includes problems with navigation, search, filters and understanding book information.
2. Summative: Compare the new catalog with the old catalog to understand whether users can find specific books faster and with fewer errors.
3. Formative: Understand whether the new catalog helps users discover interesting books when they do not have a particular book in mind.
4. Formative: Collect general feedback from users about their experience and understand what they like or what they would change.

Users : I will recruit 20 participants who currently use public libraries or are likely to use a library catalog.

The participants should have different ages, backgrounds and reading interests. Some should be regular users of the old catalog while others may have limited experience using it.

I also want to include people with different levels of digital experience. This will help me understand whether the new catalog is easy to use for different types of users and not just people who are comfortable with technology.

Participants will be recruited through library announcements, email newsletters and in-person invitations. Participation will be voluntary and everyone will be informed about the study before giving their consent.

Setting : The study will take place in a usability testing room with a computer and internet access. Screen recording software will also be used to record how participants interact with the catalog.

Both the old and new catalogs will be available through the same web browser. They will have similar book records and availability information so that participants can complete the same type of tasks in both systems.

Before each session I will make sure that both catalogs are working properly and ready to use. All participants will use the same computer and browser to keep the testing conditions consistent.

Researcher Roles :

Researcher A: Moderator

Researcher A will be responsible for interacting with the participants during the study.

- Welcome participants and explain the purpose of the study.
- Get their consent before starting the session.
- Explain the think-aloud method and ask them to share their thoughts while using the catalog.
- Give the task instructions without telling them how to complete the tasks.
- Conduct the final interview and collect feedback.
- Help participants only when they ask for help or are unable to continue.

Researcher B: Observer and Note-taker

Researcher B will observe the participants and record what happens during the study.

- Note usability problems and difficulties during each task.
- Observe where participants hesitate or make mistakes.
- Record task completion time and whether they successfully complete each task.
- Note their comments and reactions.
- Reset the computer and testing environment before the next participant.

Methods : I will use a combination of qualitative usability testing and controlled comparative testing.

Each session will take around 60 to 75 minutes. Participants will be asked to keep 90 minutes available in case the session takes longer than expected. The study will follow this process:

1. Introduction and consent (10 minutes)

Researcher A will welcome the participant and explain what the study is about. They will also get consent and explain how the session will work.

Participants will be told that we are testing the catalog and not their ability to use a computer. This will help them feel more comfortable during the study.

2. Think-aloud testing with the new catalog (15 to 20 minutes)

Participants will complete two tasks using the new catalog. While doing these tasks they will be asked to think aloud and share what they are looking for, what they notice and what they expect to happen.

Researcher B will observe and note any problems or difficulties that come up during the tasks.

3. Comparing the old and new catalogs (25 to 30 minutes)

Participants will complete two book-finding tasks using both catalogs.

To avoid the order of testing affecting the results, half of the participants will use the new catalog first and then the old one. The other half will use the old catalog first and then the new one.

I will use similar but different book examples in both systems so that participants do not simply remember the answers from their first attempt.

Researcher B will record the time taken, errors and whether participants complete the tasks successfully. After this, Researcher A will ask which catalog they preferred for finding books and why.

4. Final interview and feedback (10 minutes)

Researcher A will ask participants about their overall experience with the new catalog. I want to understand what they liked, what they found confusing and what they think should be improved.

5. Closing (5 minutes)

Researcher A will thank the participants for their time and provide any agreed compensation.

Tasks

1. Think-aloud tasks

Each participant will complete these two tasks using the new catalog.

Task A: Browsing and discovering books

"You have some free time and want to read something interesting. You do not have a particular book or author in mind. Explore the catalog and find a book that interests you. While doing this explain what you are looking at and how you decide which book you might want to read."

This task will help me understand whether users can explore the catalog easily and discover books they were not already looking for.

Task B: Exploring book information

"You have found a book that looks interesting. Explore its details and find out whether it is available, where you can find it and what other information would help you decide whether to borrow it."

This task will help me understand whether users can easily find and understand important book information.

2. Comparing the old and new catalogs

All participants will complete both tasks in both catalog systems.

Task A: Finding a specific book

"You are looking for the book *The Alchemist* by Paulo Coelho. Find the correct book in the catalog and check whether it is currently available to borrow."

Task B: Finding a book using filters

"You want to read a science fiction book that was published within the last five years and is currently available to borrow. Use the catalog to find a book that matches these requirements and check its availability."

These tasks will help me understand how easily users can find specific books and whether the new catalog makes searching and filtering faster.

Metrics

1. Think-aloud tasks

Quantitative:

- Number of usability errors during each task.
- Number of participants who successfully complete each task.
- Number of times participants need help.

Qualitative:

- What problems users face while browsing.
- What they think and expect while using the catalog.
- Where they get confused or have difficulty finding information.

- Which features help them discover new books.

2. Comparing the old and new catalogs

Quantitative:

- Time taken to complete each task.
- Number of participants who successfully complete each task.
- Number of errors or incorrect selections.
- Number of times users go back or repeat an action.
- Number of participants who prefer the new catalog over the old one.

Qualitative:

- Why participants prefer one catalog over the other.
- What difficulties they face while searching and using filters.
- How easy it is to understand the book information in each catalog.

3. Final interview

I will collect general feedback by asking participants questions such as:

- What is your overall experience with the new catalog?
- Was it easy to browse and discover new books? Why or why not?
- Was it easy to find a specific book?
- What did you find confusing or frustrating?
- Which features did you find most useful?
- What would you change or improve?
- Would you prefer using the new catalog over the old one? Why?

Expected Outcomes

Through this study I want to understand how people actually use the new library catalog and where they face difficulties.

The results will help the design team understand whether the new catalog makes book discovery easier and whether users can find specific books faster than before.

It will also help identify areas that need improvement such as navigation, search, filters and the way book information is displayed.

Based on the findings the design team can make changes to the catalog and test it again. This will help improve the design through an iterative process.